**DATE: 28/07/2026**

# EXPERIMENT – 2

### EXPLORING THE ZOHO CREATOR LOW-CODE DEVELOPMENT PLATFORM

## 1. Aim

To get a working, hands-on understanding of the Zoho Creator low-code platform: setting up a trial workspace, walking through the layout of its administrator console, and working out what each module under the Develop, Deploy and Manage headings is actually for.

## 2. Objectives

- Sign up for a Zoho Creator trial workspace and put together a small sample application to use as a reference point while touring the console.
- Go through the left navigation panel of the admin console and list out every module placed under Develop, Deploy and Manage.
- Record, with screenshots, what each module does and which options sit inside it.
- Work out why a low-code platform keeps the tasks of building, releasing and administering an application on separate, dedicated screens instead of mixing them into one.
- Note where a module's options depend on the account's plan or role, rather than assume every workspace sees an identical console.

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## 3. Requirements

| Item | Details |
|---|---|
| Platform | Zoho Creator (creator.zoho.in) — 15-day free trial |
| Browser | Google Chrome |
| Operating System | Windows 11 |
| Account Role | Super Admin, single-member workspace |
| Sample Application | "Campus Event Tracker" |

## 4. Theory

Zoho Creator falls under a broader category of tools known as low-code platforms. Instead of writing an application line by line, a developer puts it together mostly through visual builders — forms that collect data, reports and pages that present it back, and automated workflows that react to it — while the platform quietly handles the database, hosting and interface underneath. Where the drag-and-drop builder cannot express a particular piece of logic, Deluge, a scripting language built specifically

for the Zoho ecosystem, fills the gap without forcing a switch to an entirely separate development environment.

Every solution created on the platform, whether a full application, a BI & Analytics report, an integration flow, or an RPA flow, sits inside a workspace, and the organisation's namespace doubles up as that workspace's name. The account owner who first registers becomes the super admin of the default workspace and can bring in developers, ordinary users, or app-specific admins as the workload grows.

The admin console is arranged to mirror this life cycle rather than list every setting on one long page. Develop is where a solution gets built, holding both the main application builder and Microservices for reusable back-end logic. Deploy is where a finished solution actually reaches its audience, whether through a staged release pipeline, a mobile app, or a portal for outside users. Manage is where the administrative side of the account lives — who has access, how that access is secured, how usage is tracked, and how the subscription itself is billed. Splitting these three concerns across separate screens keeps a multi-person team from stepping on each other's work while building, releasing and running the same account.

The console screen itself is built out of four regions that stay the same no matter which module is open: a left navigation panel for moving between Develop, Deploy and Manage; a central workspace that shows whichever module is currently selected; a top bar that carries workspace switching, account details and a link to other Zoho services; and a help panel for guides and support. Which of these a particular member actually sees depends on their role — a plain application user, for example, is only shown the applications shared with them and cannot reach the admin modules at all, while a super admin sees the full panel described in this report.

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## 5. Procedure

1. Registered a trial workspace at creator.zoho.in and confirmed the sign-up through the verification e-mail link.
2. Built a blank sample application named "Campus Event Tracker" from the Solutions area, mainly to have something on screen while exploring the console.
3. Opened the admin console and read through the left navigation panel to see how its modules were grouped under Develop, Deploy and Manage.
4. Opened each module in turn, following the same order the panel lists them in — Develop first, Manage last.
5. Took a screenshot of every module that showed configurable content and jotted down a short note on its purpose.
6. Put together the notes and screenshots collected in the previous step into the observations recorded below.

## 6. Observations

The left navigation panel of the admin console groups eleven modules under three headings, listed in Table 2 below.

| Category | Modules |
|---|---|
| DEVELOP | Solutions, Microservices |
| DEPLOY | Environments, Mobile, Portal |
| MANAGE | Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing |

## A. DEVELOP

The Develop group holds the tools used to build a solution, together with any independent back-end pieces it might rely on.

### A.1 Solutions

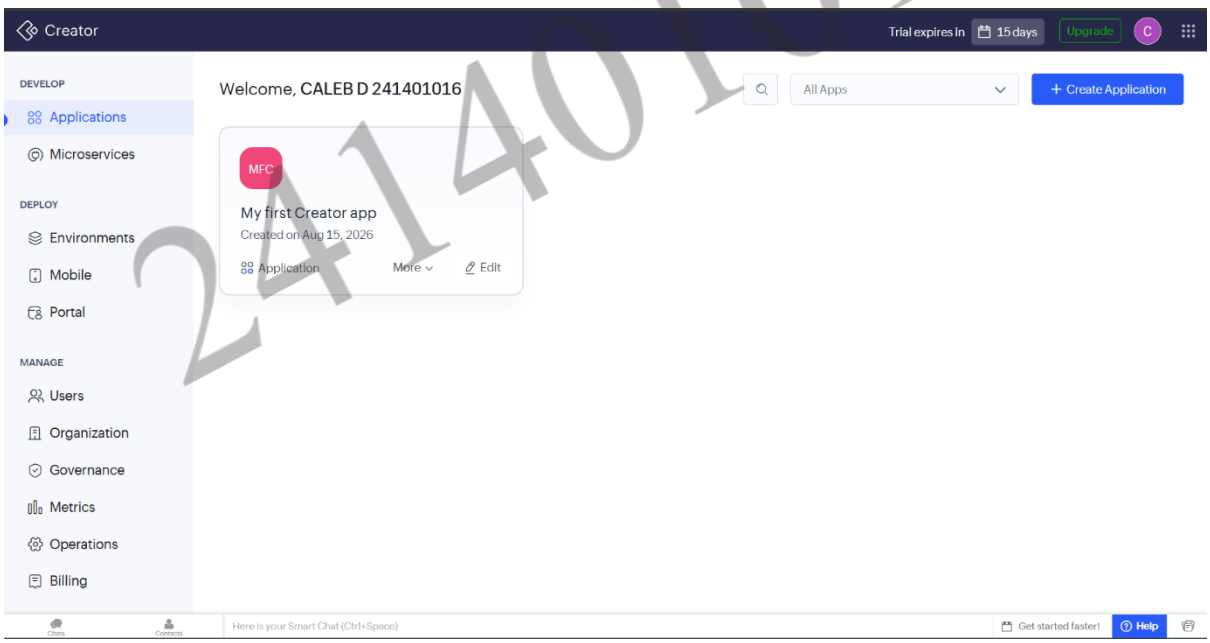



*Fig. 1 — Solutions module showing the sample application created for this experiment*

Solutions is the screen a developer lands on right after signing in. It works like a card catalogue — every application, BI & Analytics report, integration flow and RPA flow built under the workspace shows up here as a card carrying its name, icon and creation date. Fig. 1 shows the single sample application built for this experiment, “Campus Event Tracker,” created under the account of [Your Name] ([Your Roll Number]).

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- **Create Solution** — opens a menu with four starting points: a blank canvas, a gallery template, an imported data file, or Zia, Creator's AI app builder, which puts together a first draft from a plain-language description.
- **Edit** — takes the developer into the builder, where forms, reports, pages and Deluge scripts are assembled.
- **Ellipsis menu** — offers duplicate, rename, disable and delete for the selected solution, along with a shortcut to its application-level settings.
- **Filters** — narrow the card list by ownership or deployment status, for instance "Created by me" or "Production only," which becomes useful once a workspace holds more than a handful of apps.

### A.2 Microservices

Microservices lets a piece of back-end logic that more than one application might need — a tax calculation, a validation check, a call out to an outside API — be written once and exposed through its own endpoint, instead of being rebuilt inside every application that needs it. This module was not configured during the experiment, so there is no screenshot for it here.

## B. DEPLOY

The Deploy group decides how a finished solution actually reaches the people meant to use it — through a controlled release pipeline, on a phone, or through a gateway built for outside users.

### B.1 Environments

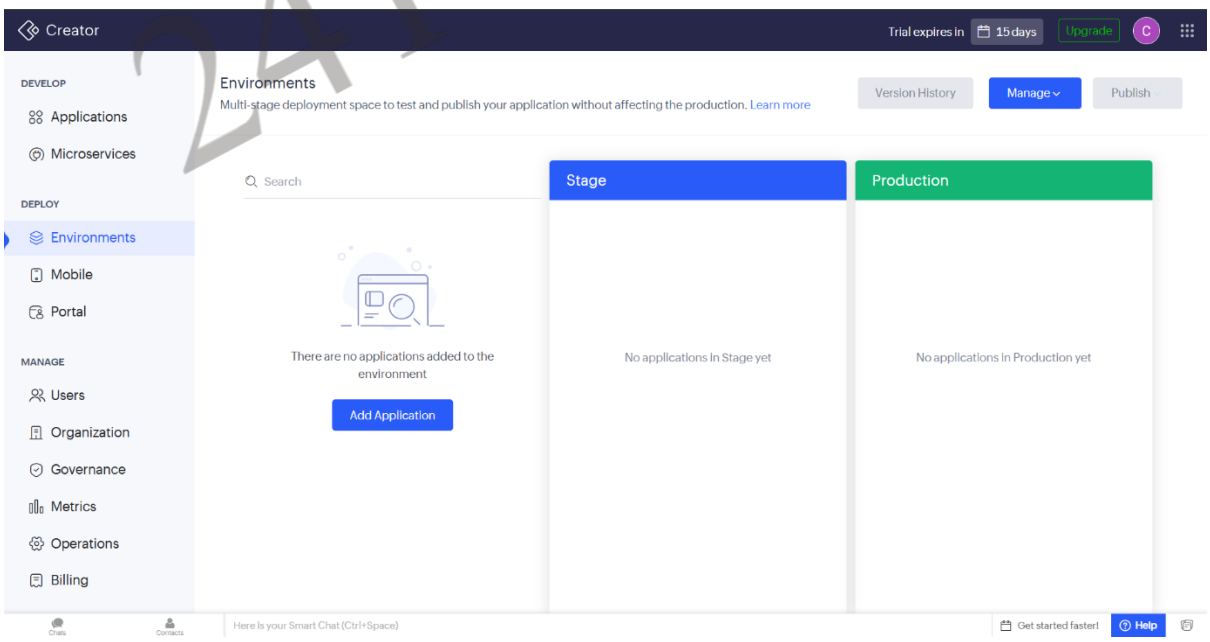



*Fig. 2 — Environments module showing the Development, Stage and Production columns*

Environments lays out a staged pipeline so an application can be tested before real users ever see the change. The screen is split into three columns:

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| Stage | Purpose |
|---|---|
| Development | The developer's private working copy, used to build and test changes before they go anywhere else. |
| Stage | A rehearsal copy that mirrors production, used to check a change is safe before it ships. |
| Production | The live copy that actual users depend on. |

- **Publish** — pushes an application from one stage to the next.
- **Version History** — keeps a record of earlier published versions and allows a rollback if a release causes problems.
- **Manage** — configures which applications take part in the pipeline.

In the screenshot, both the Stage and Production columns are empty, since the sample application had not yet been added to the pipeline at the time it was captured.

## B.2 Mobile

Mobile decides how an application behaves once it is opened on a phone or tablet. Every Creator application is reachable through the Zoho Creator mobile app by default; this module is where that layout is adjusted, offline data capture that syncs once a connection returns is configured, and — on higher-tier plans — a branded native app for Android and iOS can be requested. This module was not configured during the experiment, so no screenshot is included.

## B.3 Portal

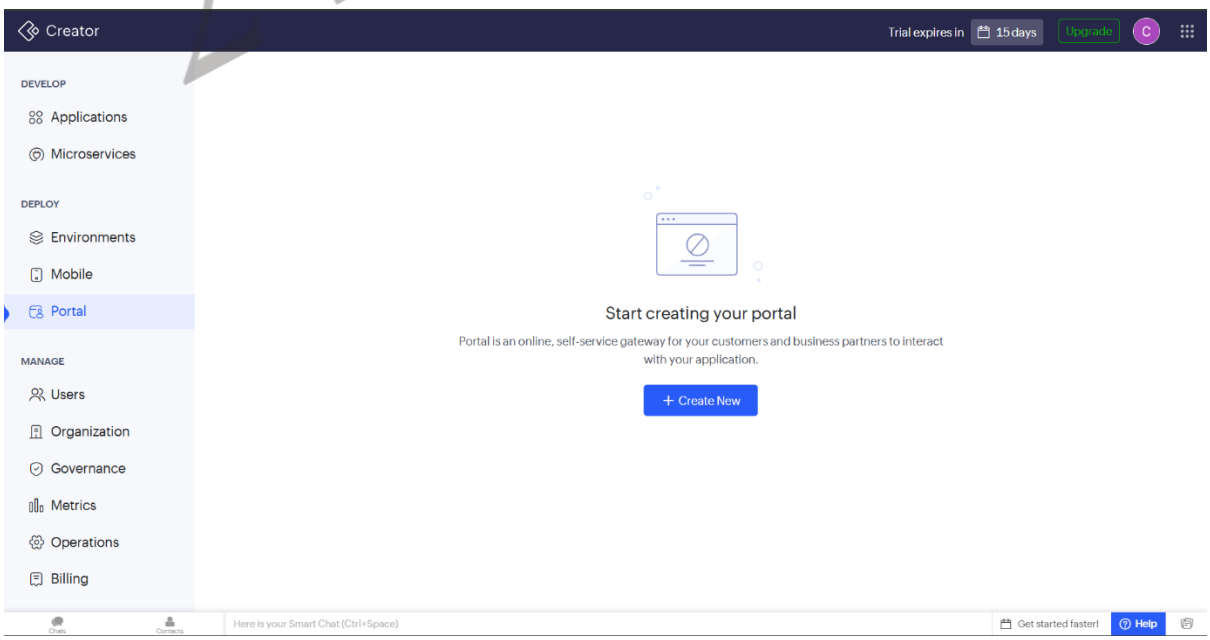



*Fig. 3 — Portal module before any portal has been created*

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A Portal is a self-service gateway that lets customers or partners interact with an application without holding a full seat on the account — a student raising a maintenance request, for instance, while staff continue to use the complete application. Portal users are counted and billed separately from internal users for this reason. No portal had been created at the time of the experiment, so the screen shows its empty state with a button to start one.

## C. MANAGE

The Manage group holds the administrative side of the account — who its users are, how the organisation identifies itself, how access is secured, how usage is tracked, and how billing is handled.

### C.1 Users

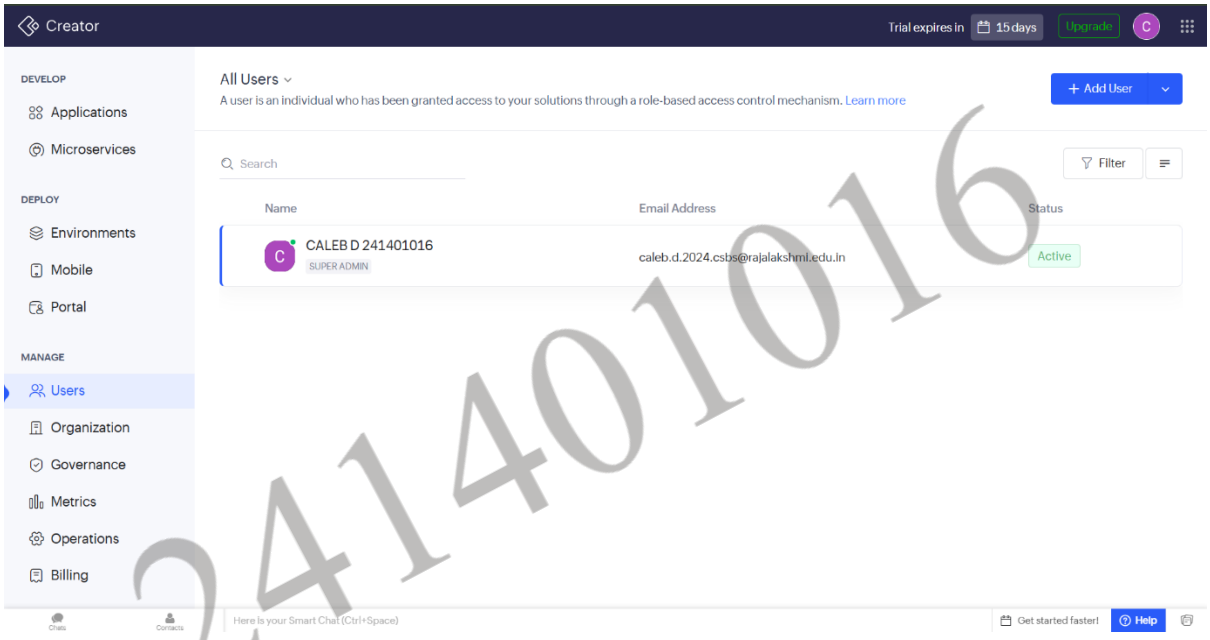



*Fig. 4 — Users module listing the Super Admin of the workspace*

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Users lists everyone who has been granted access to the workspace's applications, and access itself is handed out through roles rather than to individual people. The screenshot lists a single entry — [Your Name] ([Your Roll Number]) — marked Super Admin with an Active status, since no other member had been invited yet.

- **Add User** — invites a new member by e-mail and assigns the role that decides what they can see and do.
- **Status column** — shows whether an invited member has accepted the invite (Active) or is still pending.
- **Filter and search** — helps locate a member by role, status or name once a workspace has more than a few of them.

Because access is tied to a role rather than a person, a new member gets the correct level of access simply by being placed in the right role, and that role can be changed later without having to

reconfigure the member individually. Zoho Creator ships with a handful of standard roles that this screen assigns members into:

| Role | Typical access |
|---|---|
| Super Admin | Full control of the workspace, every application in it, and the Manage modules themselves. Assigned by default to whoever created the workspace. |
| Admin | Broad access across the workspace's applications, without necessarily owning the account's billing or organisation settings. |
| Developer | Can build and edit applications assigned to them but has no reach into workspace-wide settings such as Billing or Governance. |
| User | Uses the applications shared with them — entering and viewing records — without any access to the builder or the admin console. |

## C.2 Organization

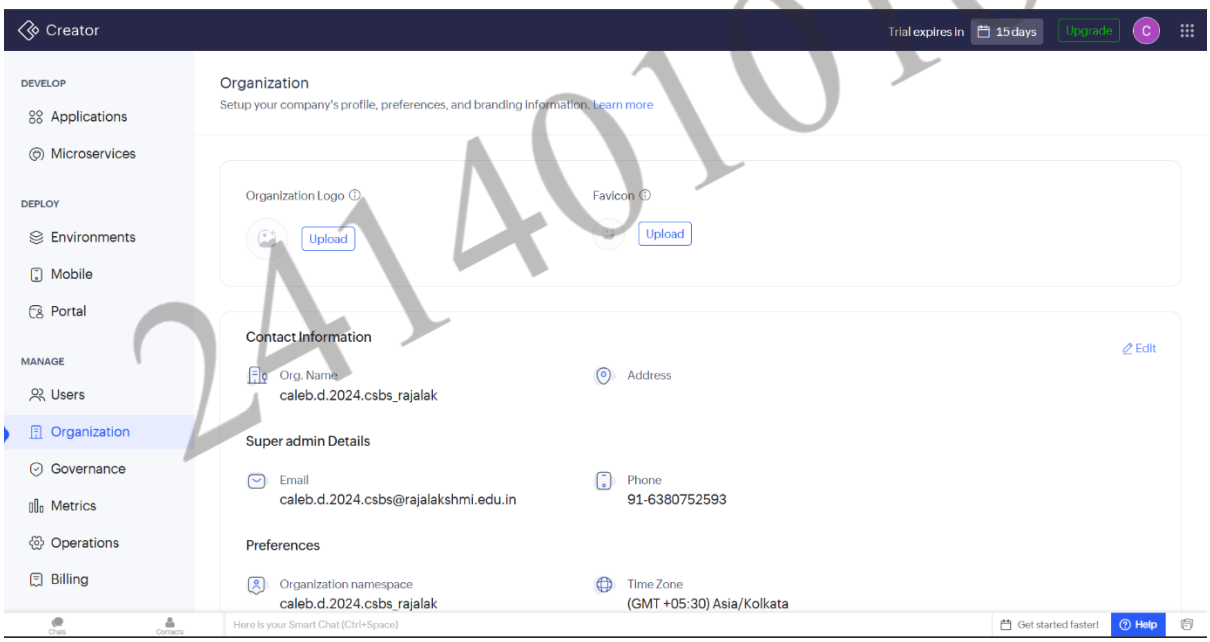



*Fig. 5 — Organization module showing profile, admin details and preferences*

Organization holds the identity and default preferences shared across every solution in the workspace.

| Setting | Purpose |
|---|---|
| Organization Logo / Favicon | Branding images carried across the applications and portals built under the workspace. |
| Contact Information | The registered name and address of the organisation. |
| Super Admin Details | The e-mail address and phone number used for account recovery and critical alerts. |

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| Setting | Purpose |
|---|---|
| Organization Namespace | A unique identifier that becomes part of the URL for every application built under the workspace. |
| Time Zone | The default time zone applied to timestamps and scheduled workflows. |

For this account, the organisation name and namespace were both left at the default assigned during sign-up, and the time zone was set to (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata.

## C.3 Governance

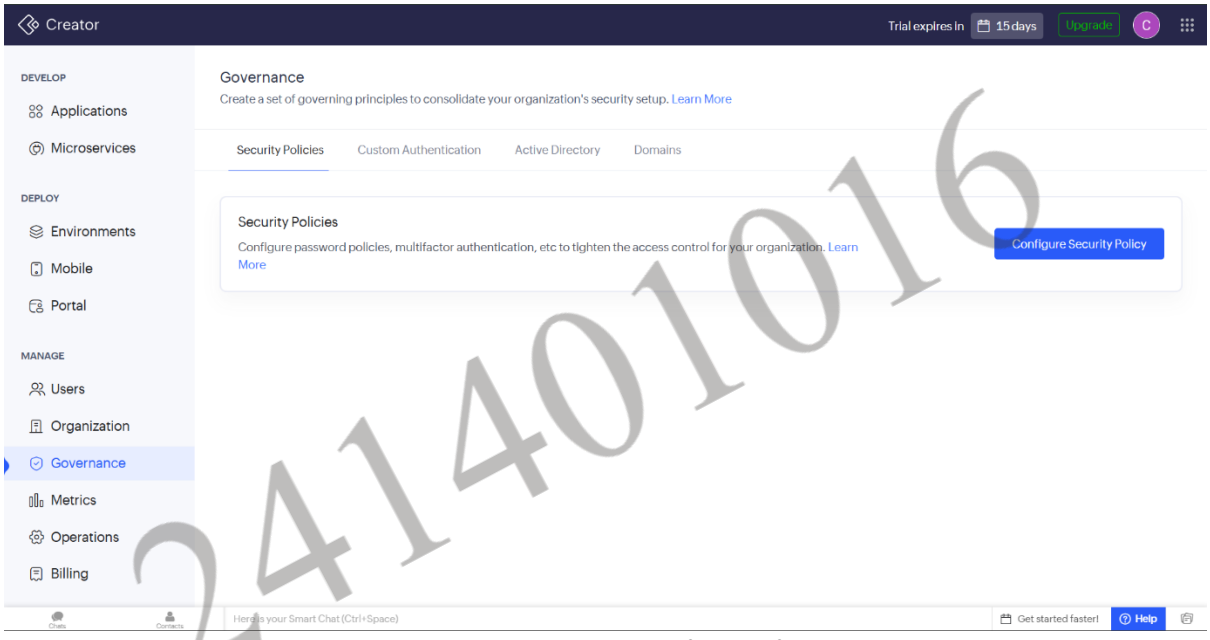



*Fig. 6 — Governance module with its four configuration tabs*

Governance draws together the settings that shape the account's security posture, spread across four tabs and backed, behind the scenes, by Zoho Directory.

| Tab | Function |
|---|---|
| Security Policies | Sets password-strength rules, password expiry and multi-factor authentication for the account. |
| Custom Authentication | Lets members sign in through an outside identity provider instead of a Zoho account. |
| Active Directory | Syncs users and groups in from a corporate Active Directory so access follows the existing directory structure. |
| Domains | Registers and verifies a custom domain so applications can be hosted at the organisation's own address rather than a default Zoho URL. |

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## C.4 Metrics

Metrics reports usage against the limits of the current plan — records stored, API calls consumed, active users and storage used — which lets an administrator catch a threshold before it is hit rather than after. This module was not opened during the experiment, so no screenshot has been included.

## C.5 Operations

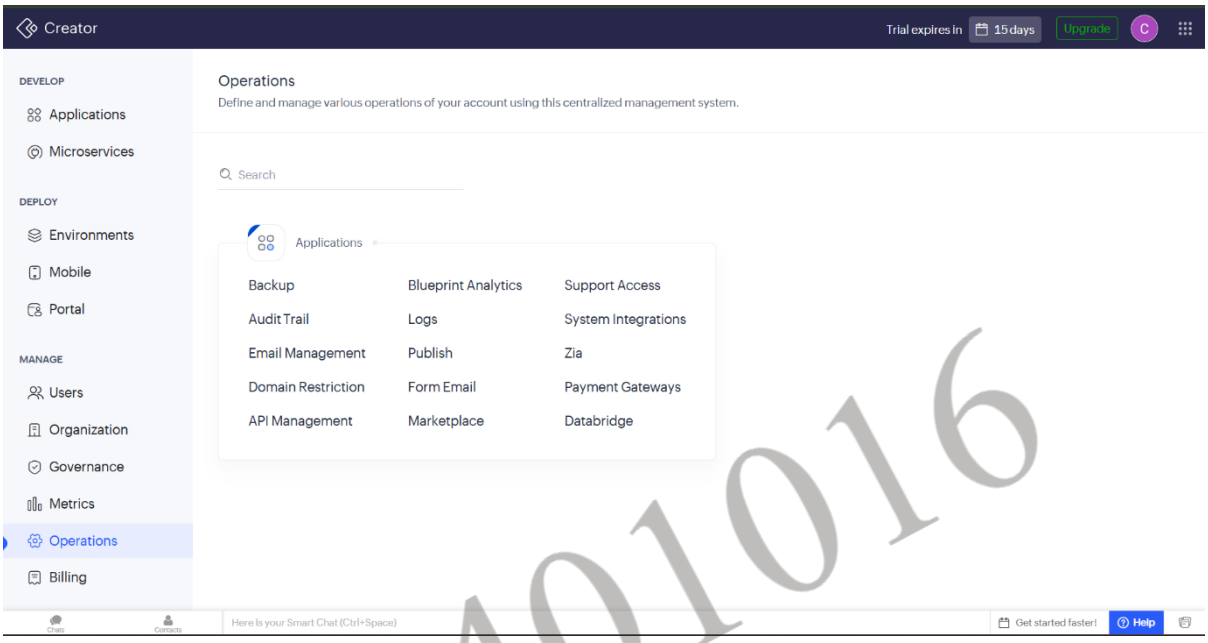



*Fig. 7 — Operations module listing the account-level operational tools*

Operations gathers the account's day-to-day operational tools onto one screen, all listed under an Applications panel and searchable by name. Table 6 lists what was found there, in alphabetical order, along with a short note on what each tool is used for.

| Tool | Function |
|---|---|
| API Management | Issues and controls the API keys and endpoints external systems use to reach an application. |
| Audit Trail | Logs which member performed which action and when, mainly for accountability and compliance. |
| Backup | Takes a copy of an application's data and schema so it can be restored after accidental loss. |
| Blueprint Analytics | Reports on how Blueprints — the visual process flows — are performing, and flags stages where records are stuck. |
| Databridge | Keeps data in sync between Creator and an on-premises or external database. |
| Domain Restriction | Limits sign-in to members whose e-mail address belongs to an approved domain. |

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| Tool | Function |
|---|---|
| Email Management | Sets the sender addresses and templates used for an application's notifications. |
| Form Email | Lets a new record be created in an application straight from an incoming e-mail. |
| Logs | Shows system and script execution logs, mainly used to trace errors. |
| Marketplace | Offers ready-made templates and extensions that can be installed straight into the workspace. |
| Payment Gateways | Connects payment providers so a form can accept payments directly. |
| Publish | Controls how an application, or individual pieces of it, are exposed to the public. |
| Support Access | Temporarily lets the Zoho support team view the account while resolving a raised issue. |
| System Integrations | Connects Creator to other Zoho products and outside applications. |
| Zia | Creator's built-in AI assistant, used for prediction, data enrichment and conversational access to application data. |

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## C.6 Billing

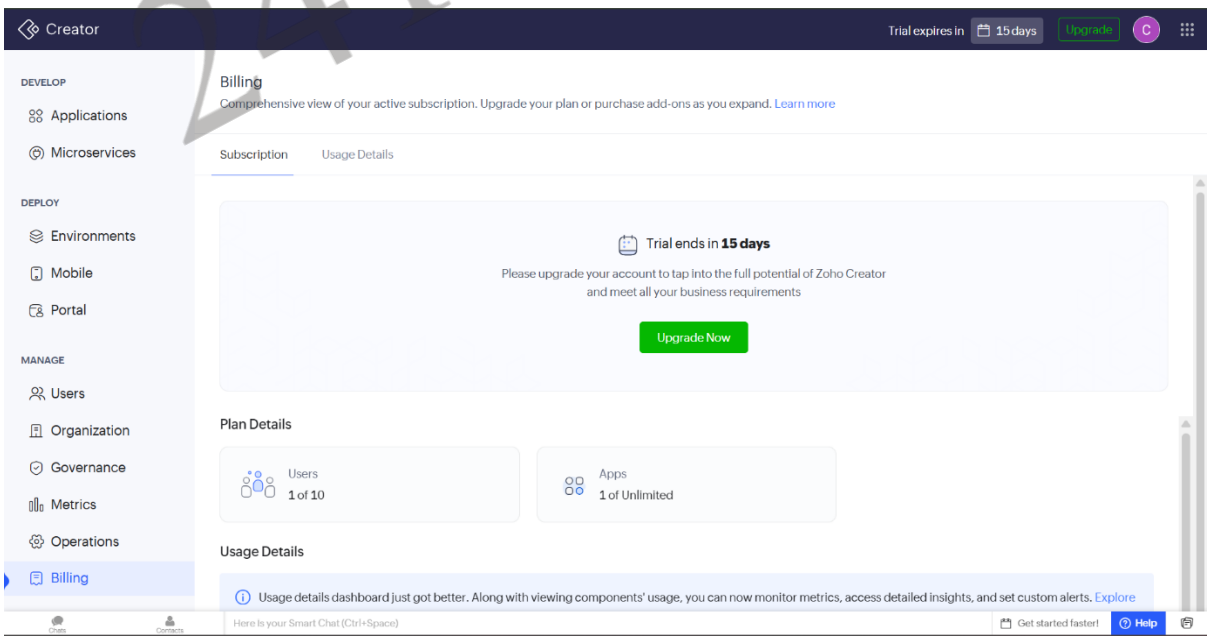



*Fig. 8 — Billing module showing trial status, plan details and usage*

Billing gives a full picture of the account's active subscription, split into a Subscription tab and a Usage Details tab.

- **Trial status** — a banner shows how many days remain on the trial, with an Upgrade Now button to move onto a paid plan.
- **Plan Details** — shows consumption against the plan's entitlement; this account had used one of ten permitted member seats and one of an unlimited number of applications at the time of the screenshot.
- **Usage Details** — breaks usage down by component and lets custom alerts be set before a limit is reached.

## 7. Result

The Zoho Creator platform was explored from sign-up through to a full walk-through of its admin console. A sample application was built, every module under Develop, Deploy and Manage was opened at least once, and the purpose of each was recorded above along with a screenshot wherever the module had something configured to show.

Of the eleven modules, eight had visible, configurable content at the time of the experiment and were captured in Fig. 1 through Fig. 8. The remaining three — Microservices, Mobile and Metrics — were left at their default, unconfigured state since the trial workspace had no reusable back-end service, no branded mobile build, and not enough activity yet to generate usage statistics; their purpose is still recorded above from the console's own description of each screen.

## 8. Conclusion

Working through the console screen by screen makes the platform's underlying design fairly easy to read. Develop supplies the building tools — Solutions for the application itself and Microservices for logic that more than one application might share. Deploy supplies the release tools — Environments for a staged pipeline, Mobile for delivery on a phone, and Portal for controlled access by people outside the account. Manage supplies the administrative tools — Users for role-based access, Organization for identity and branding, Governance for security policy, Metrics for usage analytics, Operations for backups and integrations, and Billing for the subscription itself.

The bigger takeaway from this exercise is what a low-code platform actually removes from a developer's plate. None of the database design, server hosting, access control or deployment pipeline had to be written by hand for "Campus Event Tracker" to exist — Zoho Creator supplied all of it as a configurable service, leaving the application's own logic as close to the only thing that still had to be built.

That said, the platform is only doing for Zoho Creator what most low-code tools do in some form: replace hand-written infrastructure with configuration screens, and replace a single monolithic settings page with a console organised around Develop, Deploy and Manage. Recognising that structure here should make it easier to find the equivalent screens on a different low-code platform later, since the underlying life cycle — build, release, administer — stays the same even when the module names change.

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